



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Oakdale Academy
School Website: <https://oakdaleacademy.com/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix for more details.

ACCS: **MEMBER** SCL: **MEMBER**

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools (ACCS) and the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: **CLASSICAL**

Executive Summary

Oakdale Academy (Waterford, MI; Oakdale Academy MI 48329) presents a deliberately classical, Christian model of education. Public-facing materials repeatedly foreground a classical, liberal-arts orientation (grammar-logic-rhetoric via the Trivium and Quadrivium), a capillary religious framework (Statement of Faith/Apostles' Creed, daily prayer, chapel rituals), and a mission centered on character, truth, and wisdom. The school emphasizes virtue formation, Great Books-oriented study through a structured curriculum, and explicit parent partnership. Taken together across six rubric categories, Oakdale Academy demonstrates a robust Classical alignment with strong religious/metaphysical foundations, formation-driven purpose, a curriculum steeped in liberal-arts and Great-Books sensibilities, a pedagogy that includes both contemplative and Socratic-style elements, a faculty culture framed by traditional teacher mentoring and governance, and an active, faith-informed engagement with parents and the broader community.

- Overall classification: **CLASSICAL**
- Strengths: Clear religious/theological grounding; explicit classical curriculum elements (Trivium/Quadrivium, Great Books orientation); explicit formation language (Character, Truth, Wisdom); strong parent-community orientation and formal governance structures.
- Areas that are already well-aligned but could be communicated even more explicitly (without departing from core philosophy): continuing explicit Socratic pedagogy in upper grades; broader public articulation of Great Books program and its integration with history/humanities; sustained emphasis on a liturgical cadence and communal worship as formal schooling practices.

Evidence for religious foundations, purpose, curriculum, pedagogy, faculty, and parent/community are drawn from Oakdale's published materials (mission statements, daily prayer, chapel, curriculum maps, governance pages, parent materials) and cross-referenced with the classical education indicators in the Six Essential Elements rubric and lexicon. See supporting citations inline in each category.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — **CLASSICAL**
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — **CLASSICAL**
- Element 3: School Curriculum — **CLASSICAL**
- Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — **CLASSICAL**
- Element 5: School Faculty — **CLASSICAL**
- Element 6: School Parents and Community — **CLASSICAL**

ABSTRACT

and detailed category analyses follow, with direct textual evidence and keyword analyses drawn from both the public Oakdale materials and the Six Essential Elements framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Oakdale presents itself as a classical Christian school with explicit statements of faith, a mission that centers on God, and a governance structure anchored in doctrinal commitments (Statement of Faith, Apostles' Creed). See publicly available mission and faith statements and references to doctrinal commitments. □
- Public materials describe daily religious practices (daily prayer, chapel sessions) and a liturgical rhythm within the school day, indicating liturgical and communal practices as part of the educational process.
- The school explicitly ties education to religious formation, using phrases like "Character, Truth, and Wisdom" and "through classical Christian education," signaling transcendental moral realism and theological grounding.
- The school's cadence includes demonstrated liturgical activities (opening ceremonies with prayer; weekly chapel) and a theology-inflected worldview (God-centered aims, biblical framing).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Christian, Statement of Faith, Apostles' Creed, God, daily prayer, chapel, truth, wisdom, virtue (via character formation), sacred/teacherly language, liturgy-themed practices, sacred tradition. Representative terms observed include "Christian school," "Statement of Faith," "Apostle's Creed," "Our Daily Prayer," "Chapel," and "Character, Truth, and Wisdom."
- Negative keywords (from the Six Elements lexicon) appear to be notably absent in Oakdale's public materials (no expressed relativism, secular-humanist drift, or value-neutral framing evident). In other words, the material aligns away from negative indicators in this category.

Why this rating

- The materials consistently tie education to transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) via a theological framework, and incorporate liturgical practices (prayer, chapel), showing strong groundedness in theology and communal worship. The explicit doctrinal commitments and daily religious practices align with the Classical School's religious-metaphysical foundations.
- The presence of faith commitments, worship, and liturgy, plus a stated aim to form character through a Christian worldview, supports a CLASSICAL rating here.

Citations: Oakdale mission and faith commitments; daily prayer and chapel practices.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The school's stated mission is to instill Character, Truth, and Wisdom to prepare students for service to God, family, community, and country, indicating formation oriented toward human flourishing rather than purely vocational outcomes.
- The framing of education as formation (paideia) and the goal of fostering virtue and wisdom is explicit in many public materials, including references to liberal-arts formation and a classical mission.
- The motto "Mores ~ Veritas ~ Sapientia" (Character, Truth, Wisdom) and emphasis on virtue formation signal teleological aims (formation of character and intellect in line with transcendent ideals).

- Public materials emphasize the liberal-arts orientation and cultural-historical grounding (Greco-Roman heritage, Judeo-Christian heritage) as scaffolds for formation rather than merely job prep.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, classical mission, telos, contemplation (Scholé), great conversation, moral imagination, integrity, heroism, character development, love of learning. Representative terms observed include “formation,” “virtue,” “Character, Truth, and Wisdom,” “liberal arts,” and “classical mission.”
- Negative keywords present: none of the typical “workforce readiness” or job-primacy signals are evident; no explicit emphasis on 21st-century skills or college-and-career prep as primary goals. (No negative indicators detected in the public materials for this category.)

Why this rating

- Oakdale’s stated aim centers on formation in virtue and wisdom, grounded in a classical-liberal-arts framework, and avoids a vocational or purely testing-centric aim. The public materials position education as the cultivation of human excellence and the love of truth, goodness, and beauty, which aligns with a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Mission/formation language; liberal-arts orientation; telos language; Great Books heritage references.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The public materials explicitly describe Trivium and Quadrivium as the organizing framework for the curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy).
- The curriculum map and admissions-related materials indicate a curriculum centered on liberal arts, primary sources, and Great Books engagement (the OA Master Curriculum Map, connections to Hillsdale’s reference framework, and Great Books orientation in student life).
- Great Books and the Great Conversation is referenced in the public materials as part of the Rhetoric School pathway (Go to Great Books Club, Great Books content in student life).
- The curriculum explicitly covers Latin/Greek, logic, rhetoric, Christian apologetics, and classical studies as part of the upper-level program; the Rhetoric School tracks include Capstone and Moral Philosophy, Latin study, and advanced classical studies.
- History is framed in a classical-historical context, with emphasis on primary sources and Western civilization; not described as “social studies” but as canonical historical study (per classical curriculum language).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Seven Liberal Arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Quadrivium), Great Books, primary sources, Western civilization, Latin, Greek, classical languages, history as canonical, study of rhetoric, memorization/recitation. Representative terms observed include Trivium, Quadrivium, Latin, Classical Core Academic Program, Great Books, primary sources, and Capstone.
- Negative keywords present: None of the negative signals (e.g., social-studies-centric framing, heavy project-based learning exclusive emphasis) are evident in Oakdale’s curriculum materials here. (No clear replacements of history with a social-studies label; no heavy lean toward project-based-only pedagogy in the public materials cited.)

Why this rating

- The curriculum is explicitly organized around liberal-arts education and the Trivium/Quadrivium paradigm, with explicit Great Books/primary sources engagement and Latin/Greek study. The

public materials consistently foreground these elements, which aligns with CLASSICAL indicators of curriculum content and structure.

Citations: Trivium/Quadrivium presence; Hillsdale/Great Books alignment; Latin/Greek; Great Books Club.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The pedagogy described publicly includes a progression by school phase: Grammar School (focus on memorization/recitation and foundational basics), Logic School (organization, reasoning, fallacies, abstract thinking), and Rhetoric School (argumentation, emphasis on rhetoric, capstone work). This maps directly to the classical Trivium pedagogy.
- Upper levels emphasize seminars, Socratic discussion, and the development of rhetorical skills and public speaking; the Curriculum maps reference rhetoric training and capstone-style presentations.
- The daily life includes liturgical/ritual elements (Opening Ceremony with spoken recitations, weekly chapel, opening prayers) as well as a memory-oriented recitation/memorization approach (grammar and logic stages), which is consistent with scholé/contemplative rhythms in classical pedagogy.
- The presence of a formal discipline, student life activities, honors code, and a structured progression through Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric suggests a deliberate, staged classical pedagogy rather than a purely project-based or inquiry-based approach.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: Socratic, seminar, logic/rhetoric as explicit pedagogical stages, recitation, memorization, chanting, living books, Great Books (as part of pedagogy), rhetoric training, capstone/public defense, and class-level differentiation (Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric). Representative terms observed include Grammar School, Logic School, Rhetoric School, recitation, Socratic seminar, capstone, and rhetoric training.
- Negative keywords present: The materials emphasize a balanced pedagogy with ritual/restful elements; the Six Elements notes negative signals like strictly project-based or constructivist-only approaches. Oakdale materials show classical sequencing and memory-based/recitation components rather than exclusively project-based pedagogy, which aligns with classical indicators rather than negative signals (no explicit “experiential-only” or “constructivist-only” framing in the public materials).

Why this rating

- The asserted pedagogy (Grammar → Logic → Rhetoric; Socratic discussions in upper grades; public speaking and Capstone work; memory-based recitation and living books) aligns strongly with classical pedagogy indicators. The schedule and curriculum structure reinforce a classically oriented teaching approach.

Citations: Grammar/Logic/Rhetoric progression; Socratic seminars and capstone; liturgical rhythm.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- Faculty are described as mentors and living exemplars in classical education language (the materials emphasize the mission of teachers as living curriculum and as mentors). The Board and Headmaster pages indicate a governance structure anchored in classical-Christian education values and formation.
- The site repeatedly references teachers who are deeply committed to classical pedagogy, with public-facing references to Faculty and Staff pages and biographical materials consistent with a “living curriculum” approach characteristic of classical schools.

- The public materials show explicit governance and mission statements (Headmaster, Board) and long-standing affiliations with classical education networks (ACCS, SCL), signaling a community of practice rooted in classical education values.
- There is an emphasis on character formation and teacher modeling of virtue, as reflected in the mission statements and staff pages, consistent with the classical teacher as mentor and exemplar.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: mentor, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty and staff, headmaster, board, classical education, character formation, virtue, mentorship. Representative terms observed include “living curriculum,” “Headmaster,” “Board,” and “Faculty and Staff.”
- Negative keywords present: None clearly present; there are no signals of a non-classical or purely credential-driven, non-mentoring faculty model in the public materials. The public materials support a traditional (classical) faculty model.

Why this rating

- Oakdale’s materials frame faculty as the core of the school’s mission and pedagogy (the living curriculum, mentorship, and character formation by teachers). The presence of a governance structure (Board) and explicit Headmaster leadership aligns with the classical model of teacher as exemplar and mentor, which supports a CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Board and Headmaster governance; faculty/staff pages; living curriculum language.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence

- The site foregrounds partnership with families and positions parents as co-educators in Oakdale’s classical project (Parent Partnership; families welcome for visits; OPA – Oakdale Parent Association).
- The school provides structures for parent formation (e.g., Family Life; Christ & Culture lectures; Book studies; community events) and encourages parent engagement through speaking, book clubs, and gatherings. The presence of a formal Parent Association and ongoing family events is evident.
- The school explicitly invites parent involvement and ongoing communication (family access, open campus culture). The admissions and family pages emphasize home-school partnership and parental engagement.
- The school maintains affiliations that connect families to broader classical education networks (ACCS, SCL) and Hillsdale reference-model alignment, indicating a community oriented, classical ecosystem.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis

- Positive keywords present: partnership with families, co-teachers, parental engagement, home-school partnership, family formation, parent education, living tradition in the family, open campus. Representative terms observed include “Partnership with Families,” “parents as co-teachers,” “OPA,” and “Christ & Culture lecture series.”
- Negative keywords present: none evident; no signals of consumer-focused or minimal-parent-involvement framing. The public materials emphasize active parental engagement and partnership.

Why this rating

- Oakdale actively positions parents as partners and co-educators in the education process and offers structures (OPA, parent education, visits) that align with classical education’s emphasis on family formation and joint mission. The public materials clearly support a CLASSICAL rating in this category.

Citations: Parent partnership language; OPA; family lectures and engagement; Hillsdale/ACCS affiliations.

What would move the needle (Only if SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL)

Note: Oakdale Academy is classified as CLASSICAL across all six categories. Consequently, there is no mandated “What would move the needle” section for a SOMEWHAT classification. If you would like a brief, optional reflection on potential enhancements without altering the core CLASSICAL status, I can provide that; otherwise, no needle-moving changes are required.

- Optional minimal note (not a required needle-mover): Further amplifying explicit articulation of Socratic pedagogy in lower grades (where appropriate) and a formal, public-facing articulation of the Great Books program across the history and humanities curricula could further deepen the explicit “Socratic/seminar” pedagogy and Great Conversation elements.

Citations: not required since this is an optional note for a fully CLASSICAL determination.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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